These guidelines retire the concept of a level of assurance (LOA) as a single ordinal that drives implementation-specific requirements. Rather, by combining appropriate business and privacy risk management side-by-side with mission need, agencies will select IAL, AAL, and FAL as distinct options. While many systems will have the same numerical level for each of IAL, AAL, and FAL, this is not a requirement and agencies should not assume they will be the same in any given system.

The components of identity assurance detailed in these guidelines are as follows:

- **IAL** refers to the identity proofing process.
- **AAL** refers to the authentication process.
- **FAL** refers to the strength of an assertion in a federated environment, used to communicate authentication and attribute information (if applicable) to a relying party (RP).

The separation of these categories provides agencies flexibility in choosing identity solutions and increases the ability to include privacy-enhancing techniques as fundamental elements of identity systems at any assurance level. For example, these guidelines support scenarios that will allow pseudonymous interactions even when strong, multi-factor authenticators are used. In addition, these guidelines encourage minimizing the dissemination of identifying information by requiring federated identity providers (IdPs) to support a range of options for querying data, such as asserting whether an individual is older than a certain age rather than querying the entire date of birth. While many agency use cases will require individuals to be fully identified, these guidelines encourage pseudonymous access to government digital services wherever possible and, even where full identification is necessary, limiting the amount of personal information collected as much as possible.

In today's environment, an organization's identity solution need not be a monolith, where one system or vendor provides all functionality. The market for identity services is componentized, allowing organizations and agencies to employ standards-based, pluggable identity solutions based on mission need. As such, SP 800-63 has been split into a suite of documents. The suite as a whole is referred to as "the guidelines," with the individual documents referred to as "volumes." RPs are required to use SP 800-63; the remaining volumes may be used independently or in an integrated fashion, depending on the component service(s) an agency requires.

Each volume has adopted verbs that are internationally recognized in standards organizations as normative and requirements-based. When used in a normative statement in these guidelines, they are CAPITALIZED for ease of identification. For example, SHALL is used to denote a mandatory requirement, while SHOULD refers to a technique, technology, or process that is recommended but not mandatory. For more details on the definitions of these terms see the Requirements Notation and Conventions at the beginning of each document.

These documents may inform — but do not restrict or constrain — the development or use of standards for application outside the federal government, such as e-commerce transactions.

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